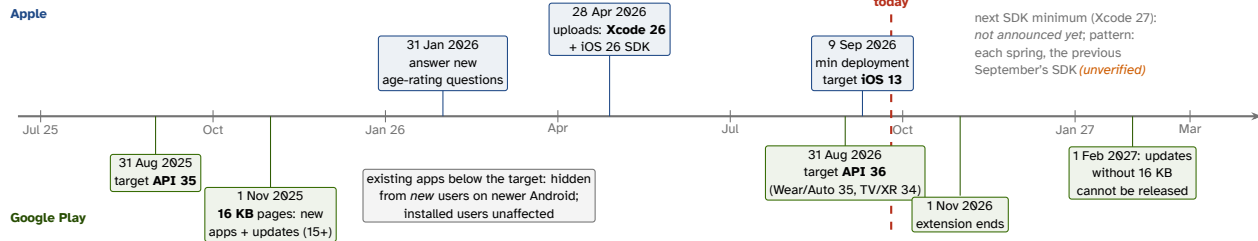


In one line: Two gatekeepers with different levers. **Apple** reviews every build against the **App Review Guidelines** (90 % reviewed in < 24 h) and each spring requires the **new Xcode/SDK** for uploads. **Google Play** runs policy checks and yearly raises the **target API level**, now also **16 KB page-size** support. Knowing the hot-spot guidelines, how to answer a rejection, and the dates on your calendar is part of senior release ownership.

Deadlines (verified on the primary pages, 25 Sep 2026)



App Review Guidelines — the hot spots

- 2.1** **App completeness:** final build, no placeholders, no crashes; **demo account** + backend live in Review Notes; IAPs complete and visible (2.1(b)).
- 2.3** **Accurate metadata:** no hidden/dormant features, new features described in Notes (2.3.1); screenshots show the app in use, not splash/login (2.3.3); name ≤ 30 chars, no keyword stuffing (2.3.7).
- 2.5.1** public APIs only; runs on the currently shipping OS.
- 2.5.2** self-contained: may not download code that *changes features* — the line RN/Expo OTA must respect.
- 3.1.1** unlocking digital features/content ⇒ **In-App Purchase**; no license keys, QR codes, crypto to unlock. **3.1.1(a)**: link-out entitlement; *not needed for US-storefront* buttons/links.
- 3.1.3** exceptions: reader apps (a), multiplatform (b), enterprise (c), person-to-person (d), physical goods/services (e).
- 4.2** **minimum functionality:** more than a repackaged website. **4.3** spam: no clones, no bundle-ID variants of one app.
- 4.8** third-party/social login for the *primary account* ⇒ also offer a login that limits data to name + email, lets the user hide the email, no ad tracking without consent (Sign in with Apple qualifies).
- 5.1.1(v)** account creation ⇒ **in-app account deletion** (details: privacy-compliance).

Common rejections — and the fix

- Crash on the reviewer's device / missing demo login / backend down during review → test the Release build on a clean device, put credentials + steps in Review Notes.
- Metadata mismatch (screenshots from another version, "beta" wording, other platforms' names).
- Purpose strings that don't say *why* ("Camera needed" → "to scan receipts").
- Digital goods sold outside IAP; a web wrapper with no native value; Google-only login (4.8).
- Demanding personal data the core function does not need (5.1.1(v): "may not require users to enter personal information to function" unless directly relevant or required by law).

Traps

- ! Discovering the SDK minimum in April from a failed upload — track it with the Xcode upgrade plan.
- ! "OTA lets us ship features without review" — 2.5.2: fixes yes, new functionality no.
- ! Arguing in the reply instead of showing: a 30-second video beats three paragraphs.
- ! "16 KB is an Android thing, we're RN" — RN ships .so files; you are affected.

Answering a rejection

- Read the cited guideline number; reproduce what the reviewer saw.
- Misunderstanding** → reply in App Store Connect's App Review messages: steps, a demo video, which screen shows the feature. Polite, specific, no argument about other apps.
- Real issue** → fix, resubmit, say what changed in Review Notes.
- Bug-fix update** blocked by an unrelated older issue → you may fix that in the *next* submission unless it is a legal or safety concern: reply asking to approve this one.
- Still disagree → **appeal to the App Review Board**: one appeal per rejection, specific reasons it complies; answer open questions first.
- Urgent: **expedited review** (critical bug fix with repro steps, or a dated event). 30-min App Review appointments exist for grey areas — ask *before* building.

Google Play specifics

- Target API** = targetSdk: raising it opts you into new runtime behaviour (API 35: edge-to-edge enforced), so budget the work, not just the number.
- 16 KB pages** only matter with native code (.so: NDK, RN, most SDKs); Java/Kotlin-only apps already comply. AGP ≥ 8.5.1, NDK r28+ aligns by default; verify with APK Analyzer, `zipalign -c -P 16` or `llvm-objdump -p (align 2**14)`; test on a 16 KB emulator image.
- Data safety** form: required for every app, even one that collects nothing; must match the app, its SDKs and the privacy policy.
- Tracks**: internal (≤ 100 testers, minutes, no full review) → closed → open → production (staged %). **New personal accounts** (after 13 Nov 2023): a closed test with **12 testers opted in for 14 days** before production access.

Remember

"Cite the number, show don't argue, fix or appeal once — and put every store date on the release calendar."